

Writing music

Sounds have pitch—higher or lower. They also have duration—longer or shorter. When music is written, pitch is represented vertically (high or low) and time is represented horizontally, setting out the notes (long or short, fast or slow) from left to right, with different symbols showing rhythm and tempo.

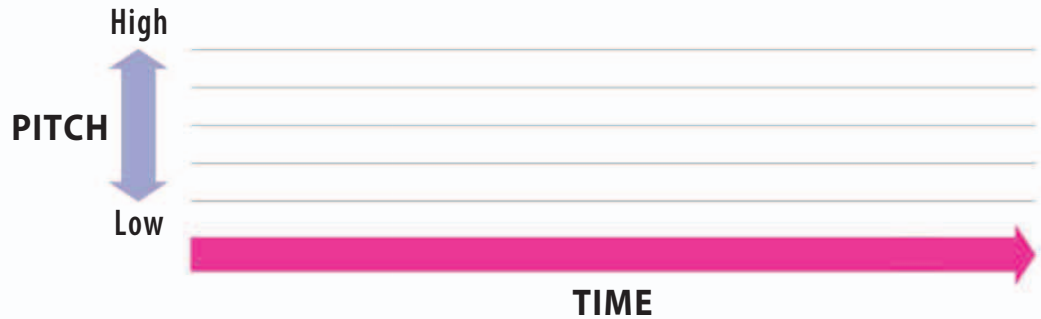


◁ Music symbols

The difference between the symbols tells us about their duration, or time value. We will learn about pitch, key, structure, and so on with the use of other symbols.

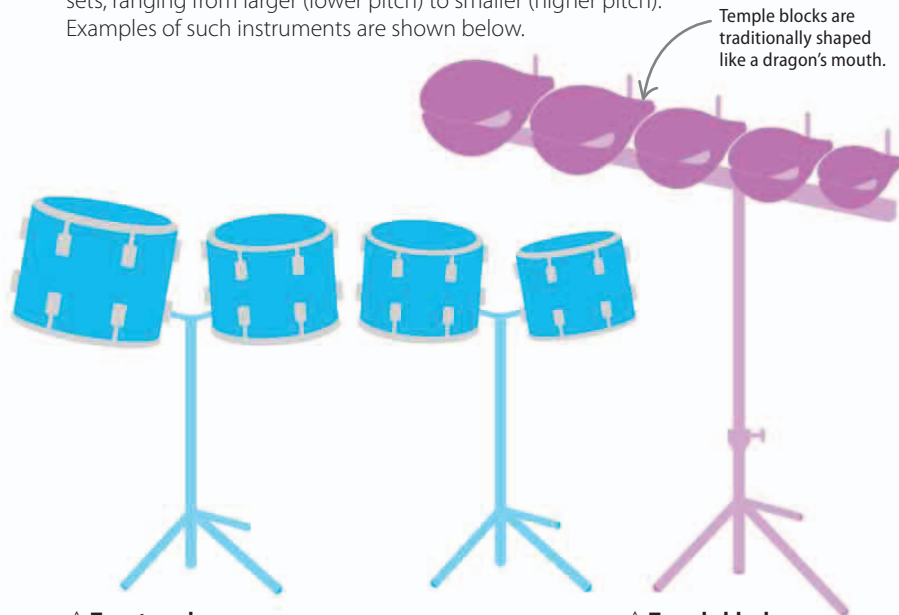
▷ Staff

The staff is formed of five thin, parallel lines. It is used to show the pitch of different notes.



Unpitched sounds

Most musical sounds have a definite pitch, but some percussion sounds are unpitched, for instance drums, cymbals, and woodblocks. They make a characteristic sound rather than having a definite pitch. Some percussion instruments come in sets, ranging from larger (lower pitch) to smaller (higher pitch). Examples of such instruments are shown below.



△ Tom-tom drum

Tom-toms are cylindrical drums that are mounted on stands; the smaller drums are higher pitched. Drummers often play a flourish from high to low.

△ Temple block

Temple blocks resonate with a wooden crack and usually come in a set of five.

REAL WORLD

Live music-making

A tambourine, with its complex mixture of metallic bell-sounds along with the hand striking the wooden shell, makes a vivid addition to any percussion group or rhythm section. Instruments are distinguished by their timbre, or tone color. This, along with the melody, harmony, and rhythm, makes a big contribution to music—what it expresses and how we experience it.

